



THE NEW RULERS

With the voluntary transfer of power from monarchy to the people an era comes to an end in the Himalayan kingdom, but the new government faces the challenge of ensuring political stability and development

■ By Saurabh Shukla in Thimphu

In Bhutan, the land of thunder dragon, history has been made. Not with the roar of a revolt or through humiliation as in neighbouring Nepal but by an enlightened monarchy voluntarily letting go the trappings of royalty and peacefully transferring power to the people. In the capital city Thimphu, with the sounds of Buddhist chants echoing across the high Himalayas, people turned out in

large numbers to vote, some in their Toyota Prados and Land Cruisers but many trekked hundreds of kilometres through narrow mountains, snailing past ancient dzongs to reach their villages to vote. Some came from as far as the US and Europe to be a part of the historic moment and participate in the country's first democratic elections on March 24, a turning point in the history of the century-old monarchy.

The elections were held by a royal decree, proposed by the fourth

monarch, Jigme Singye Wangchuk who believed that a leader should not be chosen by birth but by merit. So he abdicated his throne to his son in 2006, and announced the change to total democracy, where monarch will be the head of the state, and executive powers transferred to an elected government. Under the election laws it was proposed that the king will be above party politics and the election process. While the royal family kept away from voting, the present monarch of Bhutan, Jigme